

CASE ID: 198208710002

EPISODE NAME: US Grants Hu Na Asylum

1982/08/04 - 1984/01/01

Sender: China (710)

Target: United States (2)

Issue: Contain Political Influence (1)

Final Outcome: Stalemate after Sanctions Imposition (9)

Summary:

On 1983/04/07, China cut off cultural and sports exchanges between the United States and China for a year after the U.S. granted asylum to tennis player Hu Na.¹ The episode ended in a stalemate.

Narrative:

On 1982/08/04, China threatened the U.S. with diplomatic sanctions should it grant political asylum to the Chinese tennis player Hu Na, who defected while competing in California.² Specifically, the Foreign Ministry said that granting her asylum would “adversely affect the cultural exchanges between the two countries.”³ The U.S. eventually granted Hu Na asylum on 1983/04/05.⁴ In response, on 1983/04/07, China canceled all cultural and sports exchanges through the end of the year, calling the decision “unfair” and “a provocation.”⁵

Hu Na, a prominent tennis player in China, escaped from her hotel room on 1982/07/25, and requested asylum two days later.⁶ She claimed to face persecution in China because she refused to join the Chinese Communist Party.⁸ However, the situation sparked a divide in U.S. politics. Some officials wanted to avoid provoking China, while others felt that her claim may be invalid, as China had assured her that she could return to the country safely.⁹

The episode ended in a stalemate. Sports and cultural exchanges resumed the next year.

¹UPI. “China Today Cut off All Cultural and Sports Exchanges....” *United Press International*, 7 Apr. 1983, www.upi.com/Archives/1983/04/07/China-today-cut-off-all-cultural-and-sports-exchanges/4062418539600/.

²Taubman, Phillip. “China Tells U.S. Not to Give Asylum to Tennis Star.” *New York Times*, 4 Aug. 1982, www.nytimes.com/1982/08/04/world/china-tells-us-not-to-give-asylum-to-tennis-star.html.

³Taubman, Phillip. “China Tells U.S. Not to Give Asylum to Tennis Star.” *New York Times*, 4 Aug. 1982, www.nytimes.com/1982/08/04/world/china-tells-us-not-to-give-asylum-to-tennis-star.html.

⁴Taylor, Stuart. “China Tennis Player Gets Asylum in U.S.; Peking Aide Protests.” *New York Times*, 5 Apr. 1983, www.nytimes.com/1983/04/05/world/china-tennis-player-gets-asylum-in-us-pekings-aide-protests.html.

⁵UPI. “China Today Cut off All Cultural and Sports Exchanges....” *United Press International*, 7 Apr. 1983, www.upi.com/Archives/1983/04/07/China-today-cut-off-all-cultural-and-sports-exchanges/4062418539600/.

⁶UPI. “The attempt by a Chinese tennis star to defect...” *United Press International*, 30 July, 1982, <http://www.upi.com/Archives/1982/07/30/The-attempt-by-a-Chinese-tennis-star-to-defect/3371396849600/>.

⁷Washington Post. “China Tennis Play Requests Asylum.” *Washington Post*, 26 July, 1982, <https://www.washingtonpost.com/archive/sports/1982/07/27/chinese-tennis-player-requests-asylum/39a328c5-2f66-462d-a415-4b277dc32c33/>.

⁸Taylor, Stuart. “Tennis Defector Divides U.S. Aides.” *New York Times*, 31 March, 1983, <https://www.nytimes.com/1983/03/31/world/tennis-defector-divides-us-aides.html>.

⁹Taylor, Stuart. “Tennis Defector Divides U.S. Aides.” *New York Times*, 31 March, 1983, <https://www.nytimes.com/1983/03/31/world/tennis-defector-divides-us-aides.html>.